

Chapter 148-1

Gu Yixue was very straightforward—straightforward to a frightening degree.

Perhaps because she had achieved fame at a young age and had always been in a position of authority, she did everything according to three words: I like it.

Just like how she used newcomers, wrote her own scripts, and directed herself.

Gu Yixue's response to Sun Chengcheng was also very blunt. After she finished speaking, the air fell silent for a moment.

The other two girls were also newcomers who hadn't acted much. Their faces still carried a green, inexperienced look. These kids who had just come out of school had never seen this kind of situation. The two exchanged glances and simultaneously lowered their heads.

Sun Chengcheng paused for a moment before saying: "But I feel my compatibility with Huang Shan is quite high."

Gu Yixue looked at her, sizing her up for a few seconds: "I think your self-perception is mistaken."

Sun Chengcheng: "....."

"Huang Shan does have more scenes." Gu Yixue saw through her thoughts at a glance and bluntly exposed them. "But Guan Qingmin can become the white moonlight."¹

"They're all characters I've written." Gu Yixue sat there, her cool, detached eyes sweeping lightly over everyone present. "There's no favoritism toward any of them. Everything serves the plot."

Having said all that, if Sun Chengcheng argued further, she would be quite tactless.

Sun Chengcheng also knew how to read the room. She immediately apologized to Gu Yixue in a low voice: "Sorry, Director Gu. I just like this script too much."

"I also like it very much." Gu Yixue said. "But actors should have self-awareness about their positioning."

Sun Chengcheng pressed her lips together, looking embarrassed.

Gu Yixue curled her fingers and tapped them on the table: "I can understand that you haven't acted much and can't find your own positioning, so I'll help you find it. But... don't make me waste time on these kinds of things."

The sound of her fingers tapping the table was somewhat heavy.

After a moment, Gu Yixue stopped, and the room fell completely silent.

Only her calm voice remained: "Qi Tang, you'll play Chen Ruo. Tang Zui, you'll play Guan Li."

She assigned the roles concisely, then had them read through the script again. Only then did the meeting get on track.

When it came to interpreting characters, truly no one could surpass Gu Yixue.

Every line of dialogue in the script had been meticulously crafted. If you looked carefully, you could find connections between earlier and later parts, and you would be amazed without even realizing it.

Facing these relatively inexperienced actors, Gu Yixue showed no impatience.

On the contrary, when they raised serious questions, Gu Yixue answered very earnestly, responsibly helping them understand the characters—each character's emotional turning points, how to handle the major climactic events.

Parts that seemed unreasonable at first glance would prove to withstand rigorous scrutiny after reading them several more times.

Liang Shi had relatively more questions. For one, she had more scenes than the others; for another, she had read the script one more time than the others.

When discussing with Gu Yixue, it was more like a reasonable exploration of the character's possibilities.

The character of Huang Shan should be quite controversial, especially in the final scene where she shoots herself.

But after the discussion, Liang Shi was even more convinced of Gu Yixue's original version.

The meeting lasted nearly an hour, which was considered quite fast.

Gu Yixue had always been swift and decisive in these matters.

After the meeting ended, Gu Yixue mentioned the start date—the morning of the day after tomorrow, when they would hold the opening ceremony directly.

Sun Chengcheng had acted before, so she naturally knew that the script reading session was followed by the opening ceremony. Hearing that Gu Yixue had left a day in between, she was puzzled: "Why the day after tomorrow?"

Gu Yixue paused: "I have something to do tomorrow."

A simple and plain reason.

Sun Chengcheng had nothing to say to that.

Gu Yixue didn't lower her standards just because they were newcomers. She required them to have their lines memorized by the time filming began. As for all the beats and camera awareness, Gu Yixue would help them with those.

She said her crew didn't have many people, so many things wouldn't accommodate them.

When filming, it was work—no one should slack off. After filming was done, they could do whatever they wanted; she wouldn't care.

Their accommodation was at a hotel one street over, which was quite close.

The hotel's conditions were also pretty good—it was considered a production that was willing to spend money on its actors.

Everyone had no objections to this, so Gu Yixue asked everyone: "Does anyone have plans later? Want to go eat?"

Liang Shi was the first to speak: "I don't have anything going on."

Xu Qingzhu was on a business trip, so she had nothing to do even if she went home.

Sun Chengcheng also said she was free. The other two exchanged glances, knowing this was Gu Yixue treating them to a meal, so they accepted in unison.

Footnotes:

¹ White moonlight (白月光): A Chinese internet slang term referring to an unforgettable first love or an idealized person from one's past—someone pure, beautiful, and untouchable like moonlight. In storytelling, this character often represents the one who leaves a deep, lasting impression on others, even if they're gone or unattainable.

Chapter 148-2

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Among the group of five, only Liang Shi and Gu Yixue had cars.

Qi Tang and Tang Zui were a bit intimidated by Gu Yixue, so they chose to ride in Liang Shi's car.

As for Sun Chengcheng, she found Liang Shi's face annoying just looking at it, so she naturally chose to ride with Gu Yixue.

In the car, Gu Yixue asked Sun Chengcheng: "Do you have a grudge against Liang Shi?"

"No." Sun Chengcheng said. "We didn't even know each other before."

"Eyes can't lie." Gu Yixue said while turning the steering wheel to make a turn. "Also, why did you two delete each other before?"

"Don't you think her personality is too annoying?" Sun Chengcheng frowned and asked back. "She said she was married and told me not to like her—narcissistic to the extreme! Isn't it normal that I don't like her? Liking her would be abnormal!"

Gu Yixue recalled the details of her interactions with Liang Shi. After a moment, she said: "Whatever's going on between you two in private, don't bring those emotions in front of the camera."

"Got it, Director." Sun Chengcheng was still fairly obedient in front of Gu Yixue.

The place where Gu Yixue was treating everyone to dinner was a Cantonese restaurant. The place wasn't big, but there were a lot of people.

It wasn't even dinner time yet, and the first floor was already more than half full.

The waiter led them to a private room on the second floor. After entering, Gu Yixue first lit a cigarette, then handed the menu to Liang Shi and the others. Liang Shi passed it to the two younger girls.

The two girls were nervous and a bit intimidated even when ordering, but they still braced themselves and ordered a few dishes.

In the end, it was Sun Chengcheng who did most of the ordering.

It was also while ordering that Liang Shi remembered—Sun Chengcheng was from the South, so Cantonese cuisine was her hometown food.

Gu Yixue smoked by the window, her back to them. After finishing, she waved her hand to disperse the smoke smell before returning to her seat.

Her throat was a bit dry after just smoking, and she asked in a slightly hoarse voice: "Done ordering?"

"Mm." Sun Chengcheng answered. "Take a look and see if there's anything you want to add."

Gu Yixue glanced at the menu and added a few more dishes.

After the waiter left, Gu Yixue started to liven up the atmosphere.

Having assembled many crews before, Gu Yixue naturally had her ways. She first picked the two younger girls to ask: "Have you two written your thesis proposal reports?"

These two girls were still students.

Qi Tang and Tang Zui answered in unison: "Yes."

"This filming will take a month." Gu Yixue said. "Don't let it delay your studies."

"It's fine..." Qi Tang was halfway through when Gu Yixue chuckled lightly: "Of course, don't let your studies delay my production either."

Qi Tang and Tang Zui immediately relaxed.

Mainly because when Gu Yixue smiled, she looked very languid, like a girl next door. Their fear instantly dissipated.

Qi Tang and Tang Zui were naturally quite lively, and they started chatting from there. The private room became much more animated than before.

Only Liang Shi and Sun Chengcheng had zero interaction throughout.

After the food arrived, everyone chatted while eating.

Gu Yixue only ate a few bites before putting down her chopsticks, sitting there poking at her phone.

Liang Shi asked why she wasn't eating.

Gu Yixue shrugged: "I always eat very little for dinner."

But there was quite a lot of alcohol in front of her.

There was also alcohol poured in front of Liang Shi, but she focused on eating first and didn't drink.

Gu Yixue didn't flush much when drinking; she looked the same as usual.

Halfway through the meal, Gu Yixue took her cigarettes and phone and left the private room, saying she was going to the restroom and getting some fresh air.

After Gu Yixue left, the two young girls came to chat with Liang Shi, asking which school she graduated from, whether she had a girlfriend—all teasing questions without really expecting definite answers.

Liang Shi replied fairly politely.

Then Sun Chengcheng asked: "Have you acted before?"

Liang Shi paused. The "I have" that was about to come out of her mouth instantly changed to: "What's it to you?"

Sun Chengcheng: "?"

Sun Chengcheng couldn't believe it and said, puzzled: "Liang Shi, do I have some grudge against you? Why are you targeting me?"

"No." Liang Shi also stood up. "I just find you annoying."

Sun Chengcheng: "?"

"Why?" Sun Chengcheng asked.

Liang Shi stared at her with a frown. After a moment, she answered: "I don't like people with the character 'cheng'¹ in their names."

Sun Chengcheng: "?"

Just as Sun Chengcheng was suspecting this person was the Liang Shi from the original world, Liang Shi said with a tone of disgust: "Oranges are such an unpleasant fruit to eat. By extension, I also don't like people with 'cheng' in their names. How unfortunate."

Sun Chengcheng: "....."

Liang Shi's tone and demeanor were purely that of a nitpicking snob.

The two girls in the private room were both stunned hearing this. The glance they exchanged contained too many things, but the most obvious was shock—there's such an excuse?

Sun Chengcheng muttered under her breath: "As expected, no one named Liang Shi is likeable."

Liang Shi had been paying attention to her the whole time, so of course she heard. But when she looked at Sun Chengcheng, her gaze was still condescending, as if even looking at her was a favor. She said airily: "Sun... Cheng..."

After haltingly saying two characters, Liang Shi clicked her tongue: "Forget it. I can't remember what your name is. Whatever."

Sun Chengcheng: "?"

Liang Shi didn't say anything more to her. She said goodbye to the two younger girls, saying she was going to the restroom, and left the private room.

Sun Chengcheng watched her retreating figure, practically fuming with rage.

What... what the hell was that!

Everyone named Liang Shi was no good—they all came to oppose her!

Outrageous!

Just as Sun Chengcheng was still fuming, Qi Tang suddenly said: "Sister Liang Shi is so pretty. She's probably a rich second generation."²

Tang Zui let out an "ah": "Why do you think so?"

"Her car costs nearly a million." Qi Tang said. "She hasn't really acted much either. She only played two small roles in Zhao Ying's productions—one with only two scenes, and the other stopped halfway through filming with no signs of resuming even now. She definitely didn't earn that from acting, so the only option left is that she's a rich second generation."

"What if she's first-generation rich?"³ Tang Zui speculated.

Qi Tang: "....."

"Get real. How old is she?" Qi Tang said. "She's only been out of school for two or three years. How could she possibly be that wealthy?"

Tang Zui realized: "That's true."

Hearing this, Sun Chengcheng gripped the glass in her hand tightly.

Rich second generation...

How could Liang Shi be living better than her?

That couldn't be allowed.

No matter which Liang Shi it was, that couldn't be allowed.

Footnotes:

¹ "Cheng" (橙): The character in Sun Chengcheng's name means "orange" (the fruit). Liang Shi is making an absurd excuse to dislike her by claiming she hates oranges and therefore anyone with that character in their name.

² Rich second generation (富二代, fù èr dài): A Chinese term referring to children of wealthy families who inherit their parents' wealth rather than earning it themselves. It's similar to the English term "trust fund baby" or "silver spoon."

³ First-generation rich (富一代): Someone who built their own wealth from scratch, as opposed to inheriting it—a self-made wealthy person.

Chapter 148-3

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Liang Shi didn't care what Sun Chengcheng thought. After satisfyingly being passive-aggressive with Sun Chengcheng, she came out.

After going to the restroom, she stood in front of the sink in a daze.

Gentle water flowed through her fingers. When her phone in her pocket vibrated, she took it out to look.

It was a message from Xu Qingzhu: [Done meeting with the director?]

Liang Shi dried her hands and replied: [Mm, having dinner.]

Xu Qingzhu: [Just you and Gu Yixue?]

Liang Shi: [There are others too, the main cast from the crew.]

Xu Qingzhu sent a voice message: "Wifey, can you let me hear Director Gu's voice? I quite like her voice."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi: [Baby, do you think that's appropriate?]

Xu Qingzhu's voice carried a smile: "How is it not appropriate? I just want to hear her voice."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Or how about we make a deal—you act, and let Director Gu dub for you?" Xu Qingzhu continued with a smile.

Liang Shi listened to her voice message while walking out, then replied: "How come you get all the good ideas?"

"If not good things, should I be thinking of bad things?" Xu Qingzhu's voice was languid, and she laughed flirtatiously. "With Director Gu's beautiful voice, wouldn't it be great if she became a voice actor? Why did she insist on becoming a director?"

Liang Shi: [Baby, is it appropriate for you to praise her like this?]

Xu Qingzhu: "Can't I just give a simple compliment?"

Liang Shi listened to her voice message with the rising tone at the end twice, then replied helplessly: "No."

Xu Qingzhu: [Hm?]

Liang Shi looked at the voice message on the screen that had been transcribed into text. Those words were glaringly obvious. After a moment, she leaned against the wall, brought the phone's speaker to her mouth, and sent a voice message: "Baby, if you keep this up, I'm going to get angry."

"Really?" Xu Qingzhu asked. "What do you look like when you're angry? Come tie me up then."

Liang Shi tapped on the screen: [Tie you to the bed.]

Liang Shi: [Remember that tie from that day?]

Liang Shi: [This time I'll cut it in half—one half to tie your hands, one half to tie your feet.]

Liang Shi: [And then... I won't kiss you.]

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

After a while, Xu Qingzhu initiated a video call. Liang Shi found an emergency exit and went into the stairwell.

The stairwell had a dim, musty smell and heavy dust. It was much colder than inside. As soon as the door closed, the dim voice-activated light came on.

Liang Shi leaned against the wall and answered.

Xu Qingzhu asked her: "Teacher Liang, where are you?"

Liang Shi rubbed her somewhat itchy nose: "The restaurant."

The lighting on Xu Qingzhu's end was much brighter than Liang Shi's. Her long hair was spread across the sofa, and she was curled up entirely in it. The dark circles under her eyes were very heavy.

Video calls were much more proper than text messages.

In fact, Liang Shi even felt embarrassed for two seconds about the shameful texts she had just sent.

"When are you coming home?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi shook her head: "Don't know yet. Why?"

After saying that, she added: "You're not even home anyway."

Xu Qingzhu chuckled lightly: "What? If I were home, would you come back?"

Liang Shi paused for a moment, feigning composure: "It's not like I couldn't."

Xu Qingzhu shrugged: "Too bad I'm not home."

"Then why did you ask?" Liang Shi replied.

Xu Qingzhu: "I want to watch you go home and get that tie, then cut it in half first."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Cut it properly." Xu Qingzhu said unhurriedly. "My ankles are a bit thicker than my wrists, so one piece needs to be longer and one shorter."

After just a few sentences, Liang Shi felt like she was being boiled in a hot pot. She couldn't help but say: "Baby, what are you even saying?"

"Didn't you just say it?" Xu Qingzhu chuckled lightly, with a hint of teasing. "That you were going to tie me up? By the way, where would you tie me?"

She looked quite enthusiastic about it.

But Liang Shi was so embarrassed she wished she could find a crack in the ground to crawl into.

She was wrong.

She shouldn't have said such things to Xu Qingzhu.

In this regard, she was no match for Xu Qingzhu at all.

On Xu Qingzhu's end, she was smiling: "Tie me to the headboard or the sofa?"

Liang Shi: ".....Stop talking. Have some shame."

Xu Qingzhu chuckled lightly: "When you were texting me earlier, you didn't say anything about having shame."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi was momentarily speechless. Then she heard Xu Qingzhu say: "But I only have one request."

Liang Shi pinched her reddening ears: "What?"

Xu Qingzhu's eyes were as deep as the ocean, staring straight at her as if trying to pierce through the camera lens.

Liang Shi unconsciously licked her lips.

She really wanted to kiss her.

But separated by thousands of kilometers, this had become a luxury.

Chapter 148-4

Xu Qingzhu spread her fingers and casually draped her hand over her eyes. Her voice was half-smiling: "Wifey."

Her voice was much softer and more coquettish than before.

Liang Shi responded with an "mm," then as if remembering something, immediately added: "Baby, I'm here."

"You have to kiss me." Xu Qingzhu bit her lower lip. "You can't bully me like this."

Liang Shi's heart instantly melted into mush. She also noticed that Xu Qingzhu had covered her eyes and half her face.

She knew that Xu Qingzhu couldn't say those words without any psychological burden either.

After a moment, Liang Shi smiled with curved lips: "Then when are you coming back?"

Xu Qingzhu said: "This Saturday. But I have to attend a banquet that day, so I probably won't be home until very late. You'll have already joined the crew by then, right?"

Liang Shi nodded: "Mm, but the filming location isn't far from home. I'll come home then."

"Really?" Xu Qingzhu paused. "How about I go to your crew instead? There's a hotel, right?"

Liang Shi: ".....There is."

"Then I'll come find you at the hotel." Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi nodded: "That works too."

After all, she had never intended to hide her marriage from anyone.

It's just...

"Sun Chengcheng is in our crew." Liang Shi said. "If nothing unexpected happens, she'll be staying next door to me."

Xu Qingzhu's smile stiffened, and she said with a hint of disgust: "That annoying pest."

Then she said: "Are there other hotels nearby? I'll have my assistant book one. Let's stay far away from her."

Liang Shi: "Let's just go home instead."

Xu Qingzhu was taken aback.

Seizing the moment of her surprise, Liang Shi immediately said: "The tie is at home."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Back and forth they went, neither willing to yield.

After saying that, Liang Shi made herself embarrassed first. She had originally been teasing Xu Qingzhu, but ended up making her own ears turn red.

She thought Xu Qingzhu would retreat, but instead Xu Qingzhu's earlobes turned so red they could drip blood. With one hand covering her face, her voice was as soft as a buzzing bee—yet in this quiet environment, it could be heard clearly.

She said: "Then jiejie, you have to kiss me."

Liang Shi felt her heart turn soft and tingly, wishing she could fly to her side immediately.

But she could only hold back her emotions and say: "Then hurry back."

After finishing the call, Xu Qingzhu was already too sleepy to stay awake. Liang Shi said she would talk to her after getting home, then hung up the video call, opened the door, and returned to the private room.

However, just after she left, at the moment the voice-activated light in the corridor switched off, Gu Yixue's voice rang out at just the right time: "Jiejie, can you... kiss me too?"

In the stairwell, a woman wearing a white suit, her hair combed immaculately behind her head, sleeves rolled up, had her arm braced against the wall—trapping Gu Yixue.

Her pupils were light brown, yet her presence was extraordinarily powerful.

Gu Yixue wasn't afraid of her. She tilted her head up, the corners of her eyes tinged red, and extended her pinky finger to hook the other woman's finger. That usually languid and alluring voice pleaded softly: "Jiejie... won't you kiss me too?"